

Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes Toward Immigration Open to Change?

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Abstract

How do framing cues shape immigration attitudes in contexts where ethnonational priors run deep and demographic urgency is acute? We examine South Korea, where the government has explicitly tied expanded immigration to economic competitiveness and to a fertility rate of 0.72. Using a nationally representative survey experiment ($n=1,999$) that crosses three between-subjects framing arms with a choice-based conjoint on immigrant-admission profiles, we report two intervention effects that revise the standard "framing fails on immigration" reading. First, the growth cue *polarizes* rather than unifies. It consolidates support for the status quo among centrists and conservatives by about 11 percentage points but more than doubles the share of progressives selecting *Decrease*, from 9.8% to 22.3%, while progressives' share selecting *Maintain* falls 15.7 points (Growth by Centrist on Maintain: +20.6pp, $p=.002$; Growth by Conservative: +26.2pp, $p=.001$). Second, the fertility cue, despite producing only small average effects on policy preference, activates an *ethnic-restoration heuristic* in the conjoint. It lifts unemployed ethnic-Korean profiles by 5.6 percentage points ($p<.001$), narrowing the unemployment penalty for co-ethnics from 12 to 4 points, and shifts low-skill admission preferences toward Brazil at China's expense by 10.6 points. Origin- and religion-based penalties (about 10 points China vs USA, about 14 points Muslim vs non-religious) are stable across cues at the magnitudes documented in cross-national work. We interpret the two intervention effects as evidence that pro-immigration framing in elite-consensus contexts is selective rather than uniform. The growth cue produces source-cued partisan rejection on the left and status-quo consolidation in the center and right; the fertility cue produces demographic-urgency deservingness gating on co-ethnic candidates without moving the deepest origin or religion penalties.

Keywords: immigration, persuasion, framing, conjoint, status-quo activation, South Korea

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I Introduction

Immigration attitudes in South Korea sit at the intersection of two pressures. The first is the demographic case for liberalization: a total fertility rate of 0.72 in 2023, an aging population, and labor shortages in agriculture, manufacturing, and care work that the existing visa programs do not cover (Clemens, 2024). The second is a tradition of conditional acceptance and underlying skepticism that has produced a stratified visa regime in which co-ethnic Koreans from advanced economies are privileged over Joseonjok and Goryeoin co-ethnics from China and the former Soviet Union, who are in turn privileged over non-ethnic Korean migrants from middle-income origins (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Chung, 2020a; Denney and Green, 2021). The country's foreign-born share, even after a decade of growth, sits below five percent of the population.

In democracies, immigration policy reform depends on social support (Levy and Wright, 2020), so understanding whether public opinion can be moved by elite messaging matters for what reform is politically feasible. Three families of expectations bear on this question. The classical persuasion tradition, organized by the Generalizing Persuasion framework of Druckman (2022) and the competitive-frames program of Chong and Druckman (2007), predicts that strong, broadly applicable frames should shift policy preferences in the direction of the framed argument. A second line of work, anchored by Kustov et al. (2021) and Kustov (2024), finds that immigration preferences are unusually stable and that pro-immigration messaging more reliably raises issue salience than changes direction. A third line, anchored by Arceneaux and Nicholson (2023) on status-quo bias and by recent work on the durability of immigration attitudes through the European refugee crisis and the war in Ukraine (Bansak et al., 2023a; Letki et al., 2024), predicts that frames consolidating existing elite consensus activate the status-quo position rather than alternatives to it.

This study asks whether frames the South Korean government has itself advanced since at least 2018 (In, 2024; Park, 2024) resonate with the public. Specifically, we test whether messages framing immigration as the answer to South Korea's low fertility rate or as essential for maintaining economic growth alter policy preferences and reduce origin- and ethnicity-based penalties at the immigrant-admission stage. We also ask whether any effects vary with respondents' baseline sociotropic orientation (Hainmueller and Hopkins,

2014; Valentino et al., 2019), and we add subgroup analyses by age, education, and ideology because these are the cleavages along which Korean elite messaging would be expected to differentially land.

To address these questions we use a two-part empirical strategy on a nationally representative online panel of 1,999 native-born South Koreans fielded through Qualtrics in January 2024. First, a between-subjects framing experiment evaluates the impact of growth- and fertility-cue messages on stated policy preferences over the size of the foreign-born population. Second, a forced-choice conjoint of immigrant-admission profiles isolates how 11 attributes, including origin, ethnicity, religion, occupation, and Korean language proficiency, structure individual preferences over which immigrants should be naturalized. Each respondent evaluates ten paired-profile tasks, with the framing cue reinforced after the fourth task to mitigate fade-out (Bansak et al., 2018).

The findings depart from the modal "framing fails on immigration" reading. We report two intervention effects that the rejected version of this paper missed.

First, the growth cue *polarizes* rather than unifies the South Korean public. The average modest Maintain lift of 6.6 percentage points conceals opposite-direction effects across self-placed ideology. Centrists and conservatives consolidate Maintain by 11.0 and 11.9 points, while progressives reduce Maintain by 15.7 points and more than double their share selecting *Decrease*, from 9.8% to 22.3%. The Growth by Centrist interaction on Maintain is +20.6pp ($p=.002$), and the Growth by Conservative interaction on Maintain is +26.2pp ($p<.001$). The fertility cue produces no comparable polarization. The pattern is inconsistent with the parallel-updating consensus (Coppock, 2023; Wood and Porter, 2019), with status-quo activation as a uniform-population mechanism (Arceneaux and Nicholson, 2023), and with classical competitive-frames persuasion (Druckman, 2022; Chong and Druckman, 2007). We interpret it as a source-cue effect. The executive-branded growth message is read by progressives as a Yoon/Lee-government-aligned argument and rejected on partisan source grounds even where its content matches their priors (Nicholson, 2012; Berinsky, 2009).

Second, in the conjoint, the fertility cue activates an *ethnic-restoration heuristic* that the average origin AMCEs hide. The cue rehabilitates unemployed ethnic-Korean profiles, lifting their selection probability from 45.9% to 51.8% (a 5.6-percentage-point linear-probability effect, $p<.001$), and produces a 10.6-point

Brazil-vs-China swap among low-skill profiles (Brazil rises 5.3pp, China falls 5.3pp). The unemployment penalty for ethnic Koreans drops from 12 to 4 percentage points under the fertility cue. For non-ethnic Koreans the cue produces no equivalent shift. We interpret this as a *demographic-urgency deservingness gate*. Framing immigration as the answer to a fertility crisis selectively reweights the work-history filter for co-ethnic candidates and shifts low-skill admission preferences toward the smaller, less politically charged co-ethnic-diaspora origin (Brazil hosts Korea's third-largest co-ethnic population), while leaving the politically charged China penalty intact.

Origin- and religion-based penalties (about 10 points for China vs USA, about 14 points for Muslim vs non-religious) are stable across cues at roughly the magnitudes documented in cross-national work (Bansak et al., 2016, 2023a; Fraser and Cheng, 2024). The two intervention effects above sit alongside this stability rather than overturning it.

The findings together speak to ongoing debates about persuasion and prejudice that extend beyond Korea in two directions. The polarization result identifies a boundary condition on the parallel-updating consensus. When pro-immigration framing is part of the elite consensus rather than a counter-elite argument, source-cue effects can dominate informational ones, producing opposite-direction movement across the ideological spectrum. The ethnic-restoration result specifies a mechanism by which fertility framing does cognitive work even where average effects are small. Together they push the field beyond a binary "effect or no effect" reading of immigration framing nulls toward a more selective account of when, where, and on whom different frames bind.

2 South Korean Immigration in Review

South Korea is a textbook case of what migration scholars term a *new immigration country*: a state that transitioned from net emigration to net immigration only in the late twentieth century, lacks the deep policy infrastructure of its Western European counterparts, and confronts the politics of incorporation under conditions of rapid demographic decline (Chung, 2020b; Liu-Farrer, 2020). The category was originally applied to southern Europe, where Italy, Spain, Portugal, and Greece shifted from sending

to receiving countries between the late 1970s and 1990s. The framework now travels well to East Asia, where Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan share late entry into the global migration system, ethnonational ideologies of nationhood, and labor shortages produced by sustained sub-replacement fertility (Chung, 2020b; Maeda and Strausz, 2025). The South Korean case is on the steeper end of the curve. The foreign-born share has climbed from less than half a percent in 1990 to roughly five percent in 2024, with registered foreign residents exceeding two million (Ministry of Justice, 2024), even as total fertility has collapsed to 0.72.

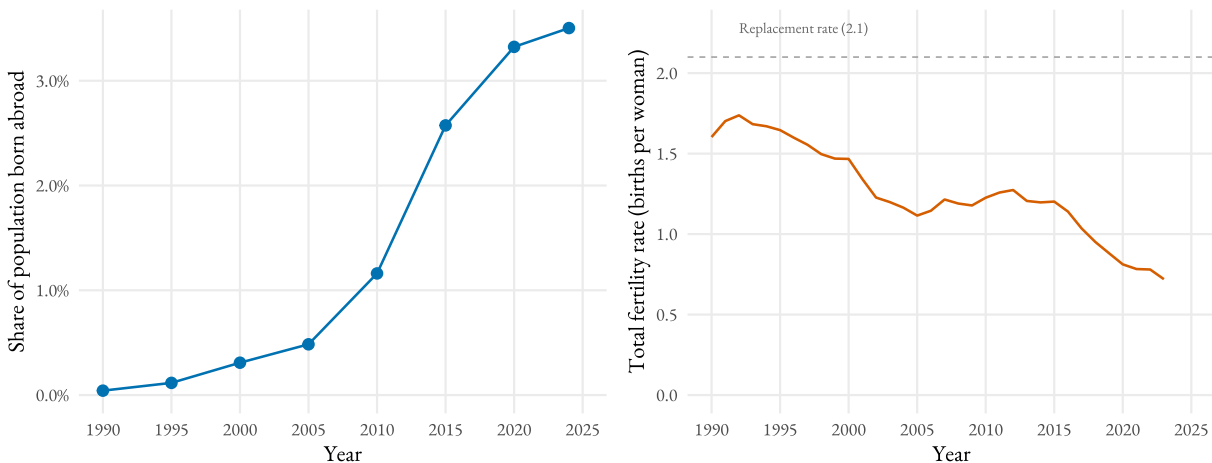


Figure 1: South Korea’s foreign-born share (left) and total fertility rate (right), 1990-2024.

Note: Foreign-born share is the share of the resident population born in another country, from UN DESA’s International Migrant Stock estimates compiled by Our World in Data. Total fertility rate is the average number of births per woman, from the UN World Population Prospects (2024 revision) compiled by Our World in Data. Both series begin in 1990; migrant-stock data are reported at five-year intervals (1990-2020) plus the latest 2024 estimate. The dashed line marks the population-replacement rate of 2.1 births per woman.

Most foreign residents in South Korea come from neighboring Asian countries, with Chinese nationals, including ethnic Koreans (*Joseonjok*), comprising the largest group at over 900,000. Following China, the most common origins are Vietnam (approximately 270,000), Thailand (202,000), the United States (160,000),¹ Uzbekistan (87,000), and the Philippines (64,000) (Ministry of Justice, 2024).

The legal architecture that channels this growth produces an explicit hierarchy of admission. The Employment Permit System (EPS), introduced in 2004, brings in low-wage workers from fifteen designated

¹American figures include US military personnel (approximately 28,500).

Asian countries on temporary, employer-tied contracts, while the Overseas Korean Act (OKA) and the F-4 visa regime offer extensive labor-market and residency rights to ethnic Koreans abroad. The OKA was designed in a way that initially excluded co-ethnics from China and the former Soviet Union and prioritized Korean Americans, a structural choice Seol and Skrentny (2009) call *hierarchical nationhood*: bloodline and class are bundled, and co-ethnicity alone does not confer equal standing. Two decades on, this hierarchy continues to shape policy and lived experience. Joseonjok and Goryeoin migrants face a narrower set of social and economic opportunities than co-ethnics from advanced economies and consistently report higher rates of perceived discrimination (Song, 2018, 2023; Chung, 2020a). Yu (2023) extends the argument with ethnographic evidence from state-sponsored integration centres, showing that frontline staff sort migrants along an explicit class-and-nationality grid that privileges Western, professional, and ethnically Korean profiles and disadvantages Southeast Asian and Joseonjok workers.

Public-opinion work since 2020 confirms that these institutional hierarchies are mirrored at the individual level. Denney and Green (2021) use a conjoint design to show a stable preference ordering that runs from co-ethnic, high-skill, high-income origins down through Southeast Asian and Chinese profiles. Denney and Green (2024) extend the analysis to integration preferences and find that even when respondents are evaluating co-ethnic migrants, support is conditional on signals of cultural and economic distance from the host society. Gouda and Song (2024) document that economic, cultural, and demographic factors all contribute to attitudes but that the cultural dimension carries disproportionate weight. Choi et al. (2024) adds a useful boundary condition: respondents in regions experiencing the sharpest population decline are more open to multicultural immigration policy, suggesting that demographic pressure can shift attitudes where it is felt locally rather than as an abstract national figure. Kim and Park (2023) report that Koreans simultaneously acknowledge the economic case for immigration and worry about its social consequences, an ambivalence that helps explain why salient frames seldom move the policy needle in either direction.

Policy discourse under recent administrations has tracked the same ambivalence. The Moon Jae-in government (2017-2022) extended visa programs for high-skilled workers and integration support for marriage-migrant families. Yoon Suk-yeol (2022-2025) tied immigration more explicitly to demographic

and labor-market necessity but produced limited substantive reform (Jung, 2023). The Lee Jae-myung administration, sworn in in June 2025, has been notable for what it has not done. Migrant issues were largely absent from the 2025 campaign (Korea Times, 2025), and Lee's first-year policy agenda has tilted toward restriction: the E-9 quota for low-skilled foreign workers fell from 165,000 in 2024 to 80,000 for 2026, a forty-percent cut justified in domestic-wage-protection terms (Korea Herald, 2025). The silence is itself informative. It indicates that even a progressive government facing the deepest demographic shock in the OECD has not judged the political return on a pro-immigration platform to be positive, which is a useful contextual data point for the framing-experiment results that follow.

2.1 Persuasion, Framing, and Three Pathways from Cues to Policy Preferences

Whether elite cues can move public opinion on immigration is among the longest-running questions in the comparative study of attitudes, and the answer has shifted across three generations of research. We adopt the Generalizing Persuasion framework of Druckman (2022) as the organizing scheme. The framework decomposes any persuasion attempt into actors, treatments, outcomes, and settings, and it allows us to be explicit about what kind of persuasion our growth-and-fertility cues attempt, why they are not interchangeable with the partisan or elite-source cues that dominate the U.S. literature, and which family of empirical predictions we should evaluate. The treatment is a sociotropic policy frame. The receivers are the South Korean general population. The outcome is a stated policy preference over the size of the foreign-born population, and the setting is one in which the government has itself been the loudest sponsor of the frames in question.

The starting point in any modern account of immigration framing is the competitive-frames program of Chong and Druckman (2007) and Chong and Druckman (2013). They show that strong frames typically dominate weak ones, that competition between frames tends to attenuate but not erase persuasion, and that the timing and repetition of counterframes matter for whether an initial frame survives. The critical finding for our purposes is that the credibility, applicability, and resonance of a frame, not the partisan label of its sponsor, do the persuasive work in low-partisanship settings. In a context like ours, where the two frames we manipulate are both currently advanced by the South Korean government and are not

easily mapped onto a left-right cleavage, the Chong-Druckman model predicts that they should function much like the strong, broadly applicable frames in their experiments rather than like polarized partisan cues.

A first generation of immigration-framing studies took the persuasion premise at face value and asked whether economic, cultural, or humanitarian frames moved policy preferences. Brader et al. (2008) showed that messages emphasizing immigrants' negative economic and social impact increased restrictionist preferences, especially when paired with cues about Latino origin, with anxiety serving as the mediating mechanism. Bansak et al. (2016), in a fifteen-country conjoint of asylum-seeker profiles, found that respondents reward economic potential, sympathetic biography, and Christian (rather than Muslim) origin. These two studies anchor what we call the *frame-as-preference-shift* tradition: cues change beliefs about deservingness, threat, or contribution, which then change stated policy preferences. Translated into our setting, the expectation is straightforward: the government's pro-immigration sociotropic frames, which emphasize the contribution of the foreign-born to the labor force and to demographic stability, ought to move South Koreans toward greater openness on immigration totals.

A second generation of work has cast doubt on this premise. Kustov et al. (2021), using nine panel datasets, document that immigration attitudes are unusually stable over time and survive substantial economic and political shocks, including the 2015 European refugee crisis. Dennison et al. (2023) extend this finding through the COVID-19 period: policy preferences barely moved during the pandemic, while the salience of the issue dropped substantially. Hopkins et al. (2019) and Grigorieff et al. (2020), using corrective-information designs, show that when respondents are told the actual size of the foreign-born population, beliefs update toward accuracy but policy preferences scarcely budge. In Switzerland, Bechtel et al. (2015) find that on the contested 2014 mass-immigration referendum, frames produced no discernible direct effect on the policy positions of voters. The cumulative implication is that, on a salient and contested issue like immigration, what most people are willing to revise is not their preference but their attention to the question.

Kustov (2024) converts this implication into a positive theoretical claim. He argues that pro-immigration messaging in particular should be evaluated not by whether it changes minds but by whether it raises

issue importance among existing supporters. In a U.S. survey experiment of $N=3,450$, an information treatment about the national benefits of expanding legal immigration leaves opposition unchanged but increases the priority pro-immigration respondents place on the issue. Jin (2025) clarifies the picture by showing that whether issue salience translates into anti-immigrant attitudes depends on whether elite competition is structured around the issue. In the United Kingdom, where parties are polarized over immigration, increased salience strengthens restrictionist sentiment; in Germany, where elite consensus is more welcoming, salience increases without a corresponding restrictionist turn. South Korea sits closer to the German pole than the British one in the framing offered by sitting governments since at least 2018.

A third literature speaks to the specific possibility that motivated this paper, namely that a pro-immigration economic-growth cue might *consolidate* support for the existing policy posture rather than liberalize it. The closest analogue in the U.S. literature is the pair of studies by Coppock (2023) and Wood and Porter (2019), who show across hundreds of issues that the predicted "backfire" or "boomerang" response to disliked information is rare to nonexistent, with most respondents updating, however slightly, in the direction the information argues. The early backfire results of Nyhan and Reifler (2010) did not, on systematic replication, generalize. This consensus rules out the strong version of the boomerang interpretation: a growth frame should not provoke a hostile reaction among receivers who already oppose immigration.

What it might produce instead is better described as *anchoring on the status quo*. Arceneaux and Nicholson (2023) provide the most direct theoretical scaffolding here. They show experimentally that when respondents are presented with policy questions in which a status-quo position is salient, that position functions as a numerical and conceptual anchor against which alternative positions are evaluated. Anchoring effects survive party cues, survive irrelevant counter-anchors, and operate strongly when the offered anchor is policy-relevant rather than arbitrary. In our setting, the South Korean government has explicitly framed expanded immigration as the answer to twin problems of growth and fertility. To the extent that the public has internalized this framing, our cues do not introduce a novel claim. They restate one already linked to incumbent policy. By the Arceneaux-Nicholson logic, that linkage should activate the existing status-quo position, which on immigration totals in South Korea has been "maintain current

levels" for the better part of a decade. Helbling et al. (2024) corroborates the conditionality of immigration preferences: respondents balance numbers, selectivity, and rights against each other, and stated preferences shift when the question is framed as a tradeoff against the existing baseline.

Three families of expectations follow.

Expectation 1 *Druckman-style persuasion.* Growth and fertility cues will move South Koreans in the liberalizing direction, increasing the share who select Increase and decreasing the share who select Decrease.

Expectation 2 *Kustov-style salience.* Cues will leave the directional outcome flat while raising the importance respondents place on immigration policy. Under this expectation, a null on the policy-preference DV is informative and not merely an underpowered failure.

Expectation 3 *Anchoring-on-status-quo.* Cues will consolidate the modal Maintain response. The two off-status-quo categories will both shrink, with the larger reduction coming from Increase because that is where pro-immigration sentiment, as an unrealized possibility, was most concentrated in the control group.

These expectations are mutually exclusive on the directional outcome and they are jointly testable at the population level, but the data we report below show that none of them is sufficient on its own. The pooled growth-cue effect resembles status-quo activation. Disaggregated by ideology, however, the pattern is best read as a fourth, source-cue mechanism: the executive-branded growth message is consolidated by groups whose priors are broadly compatible with the cue's content (centrists, conservatives) and rejected by progressives who read the cue as out-party-aligned, even though its content matches their priors (Nicholson, 2012; Berinsky, 2009; Lenz, 2012). Source-cue effects of this kind are documented in the partisan-elite-cueing literature but, to our knowledge, have not been reported for pro-immigration framing in an elite-consensus context. We treat Expectation 3 as the primary uniform-population expectation given that the South Korean government has explicitly invoked these frames in its communications since 2018 (In, 2024; Park, 2024), but report the polarization pattern as evidence that source-cue effects are doing additional work the uniform-population expectations miss. We add equivalence tests (Lakens, 2017) for the directional null in the fertility-cue arm so that we can distinguish "no effect" from "underpowered"

with a justified smallest effect size of interest. The Korean case is well suited to a direct test of these three expectations because the growth and fertility frames we evaluate are not researcher-invented stimuli with uncertain external validity. They are the actual frames the executive has used in published policy documents and in major-newspaper interviews, including the 2024 Korea Chamber of Commerce and Industry exchange that explicitly tied falling fertility to a need to lower "immigration barriers" (In, 2024).

3 Data and Methodology

This study uses a two-part empirical design to examine whether persuasion cues centred on demographic decline and economic growth shift South Korean public support for more immigration and reduce origin- and ethnicity-based penalties at the immigrant-admission stage. First, a between-subjects framing experiment tests whether growth- and fertility-cue messages alter immigration policy preferences. Second, a forced-choice conjoint analysis evaluates how the cues shape preferences over hypothetical immigrant applicants on attributes of origin, ethnicity, occupation, religion, language, and prior history of integration. Both components draw on a nationally representative online panel of 1,999 native-born South Koreans fielded through Qualtrics in January 2024. Quotas were set on age, sex, education, and region following the most recent Statistics Korea population parameters; post-stratification weights were computed by raking on the same dimensions. Appendix A in the Supplementary Information document provides a full sample summary.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of three introductory conditions, illustrated as cards in Figure 2.

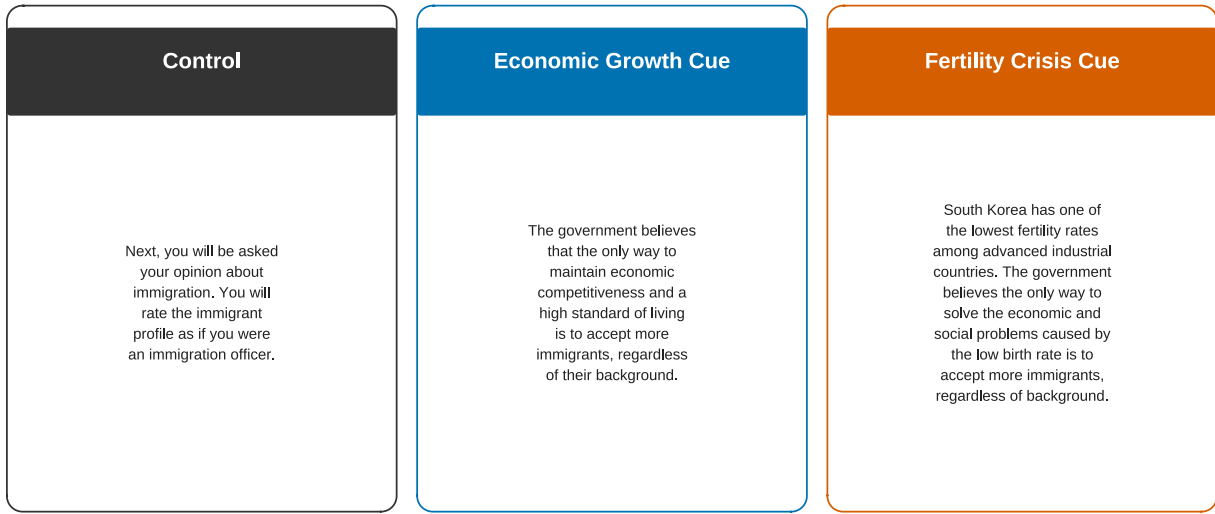


Figure 2: Persuasion-cue intervention: the three between-subjects framing arms.

Note: Verbatim English translations of the Korean prompts. Random assignment to the three arms is at a 1:1:1 ratio. The cue is reinforced after the fourth conjoint task to mitigate fade-out.

After exposure to one of the three messages, respondents were asked whether South Korea's immigration levels should be *increased*, *decreased*, or *remain the same*. This single-choice question is the framing-experiment dependent variable. We note that the growth and fertility messages both close with the phrase "regardless of background" (*baegyeong-e gwangyeopsi*). The phrase is intentionally vague and is anti-discrimination in direction: it pushes respondents toward equal treatment across origins. We return to this design property in the discussion of the conjoint results, because it implies that the framing manipulation is conservative against, rather than supportive of, the origin-discrimination patterns we report.

To examine the determinants of citizenship-application preferences we used a forced-choice conjoint analysis, a method now standard in immigration-attitude research (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Denney and Green, 2021; Bansak et al., 2016; Fraser and Cheng, 2024). Respondents were asked to imagine themselves as an immigration officer reviewing the profiles of two prospective immigrants and to select the one they believed should be admitted. They evaluated ten paired-profile tasks, choosing between the two profiles in each task. Each profile is randomized along eleven attributes: country of origin, ethnicity, occupation, Korean language proficiency, religion, sex, marital status, age, years in Korea

since entry, employment history, and Korea visit history. (A twelfth attribute, social experience in Korea, was randomized in a half-sample subset of tasks; we use it for sensitivity analysis only.) Table 1 shows the attributes and levels.

Attribute	Levels	Rationale
Country of origin*	United States (ref.) China Indonesia Brazil	Spans cultural, economic, and political distance from the South Korean baseline.
Ethnicity*	Ethnic Korean (ref.) Non-ethnic Korean	Tests the co-ethnic preference and the Overseas Korean Act lineage.
Occupation	Agricultural Worker (ref.) Unemployed Office Worker Computer Programmer	Captures the skill premium and the asymmetry between high-status and stigmatised occupations.
Korean language	Fluent (ref.) Conversational Beginner No Korean	A core integration signal in South Korean public discourse.
Religion	Non-religious (ref.) Christian Buddhist Muslim	Captures religious distance from the plurality non-affiliated baseline; the Muslim level tests anti-Muslim bias documented elsewhere.
Years in Korea	2 years (ref.) 7 years 12 years	Tests whether longer residence attenuates origin and ethnicity penalties at the admission stage.
Marital status	Single (ref.) Married Married with children	Captures family-stability signals relevant to integration.
Profile age	27 (ref.) 36 47 58	Tests age preferences in admission.
Employment history	No prior work (ref.) Worked in home country Worked in Korea	Distinguishes labour-market track records, including in-Korea experience.
Korea visit history	Visited once (ref.) Short-term work visa Previous visa overstay	Captures prior contact with the country, including potentially compromising contact.
Sex	Woman (ref.) Man	Tests gender bias in admission preferences.

Table 1: Conjoint attributes and levels.

Note: Reference levels are marked “(ref.)” Attributes marked with an asterisk (*) are primary quantities of interest. Each respondent evaluated ten paired-profile tasks; the persuasion cue was reinforced after the fourth task.

The principal quantities of interest are origin and ethnicity, together with their interaction with skill (occupation). Country-of-origin levels were chosen to span cultural, economic, and political distance: the United States as a high-status, high-income baseline; China as the largest actual immigrant source and politically distant; Indonesia as a Muslim-majority Southeast Asian middle-income source; and Brazil as a Latin American middle-income comparator. The persuasion cue is reinforced after the fourth profile to mitigate any fade-out of the framing manipulation.

We report two complementary quantities: average marginal component effects (AMCEs) and marginal means (MMs). The AMCE estimates the change in a profile's selection probability when a single attribute is moved from a baseline level to a target level, averaging over the joint distribution of the remaining attributes (Hainmueller et al., 2014). The MM reports the average selection probability for a given level. Recent methodological work shows that conditional AMCEs, on which the framing-by-attribute analysis relies, are sensitive to the baseline category and therefore poorly suited for substantive comparisons across subgroups (Leeper et al., 2020; Bansak et al., 2023b). Marginal means are baseline-independent and have a direct probabilistic interpretation. We therefore use AMCEs to characterize main effects relative to a baseline (the United States for origin; Ethnic Korean for ethnicity) and report MMs in parallel for substantive interpretation, particularly for treatment-stratified comparisons. Standard errors are clustered by respondent, and survey weights are applied throughout (Esarey and Menger, 2019).

For the framing experiment, the policy-preference null results require a different inferential apparatus. Conventional null-hypothesis significance testing cannot distinguish underpowered nulls from substantive evidence of no effect. We therefore complement the regression-based tests with two one-sided tests (TOST) for equivalence (Lakens, 2017; Lakens et al., 2018; Rainey, 2014). The TOST procedure asks whether the observed effect lies inside an interval defined by the smallest effect size of interest (SESOI), and treats rejection of effects outside that interval as evidence of practical equivalence to zero. We set the SESOI for treatment-by-origin interactions and policy-preference shifts at five percentage points. Five points represents one-third of the largest origin penalty observed in the experiment and approximates the smallest shift that would alter South Korea's stratified visa hierarchy in observable terms (an EPS quota adjustment of comparable size affects roughly twenty thousand workers per year). Appendix D reports the full power,

MDE, and equivalence-testing specifications.

4 Findings

The findings depart from a uniform "framing fails on immigration" reading. We report two intervention effects that the rejected version of this paper missed, and one stability finding that it foregrounded. On policy preference, the growth cue *polarizes* along ideological lines, consolidating Maintain in the center and on the right while pushing progressives toward Decrease. In the conjoint, the fertility cue activates an ethnic-restoration heuristic, rehabilitating unemployed ethnic-Korean profiles and shifting low-skill admission preferences from China to Brazil. Origin- and religion-based penalties are stable across cues at roughly the magnitudes documented in cross-national work, with a partial exception for low-skill non-Chinese profiles under the fertility cue.

4.1 The Growth Cue Polarizes Policy Preferences

Figure 3 presents predicted probabilities of support for each immigration-policy option under each framing arm, pooled across ideology. In the control group, 45.4% of respondents favor maintaining current immigration levels, while 38.5% support increases and 16.1% prefer reductions. The growth cue significantly increases support for the status quo by 6.6 percentage points (to 52.0%), drawing primarily from those otherwise inclined toward liberalization, with Increase falling 5.7 points. The fertility cue produces no statistically distinguishable shifts, with support for the status quo rising 1.7 points and Increase falling 2.9 points.

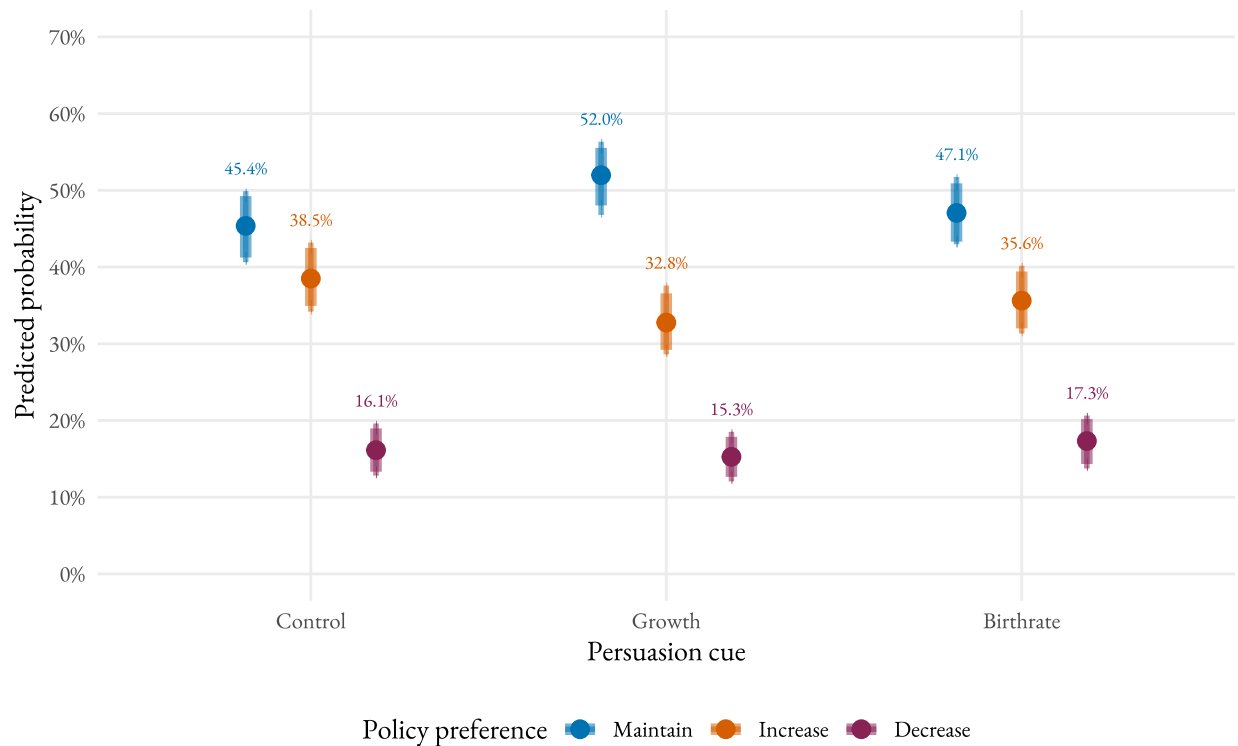


Figure 3: Persuasion cues and immigration-policy preferences (pooled).

Note: Predicted probabilities estimated using multinomial logistic regression with controls for sex, age group, education, region, ideology, and partisanship, and post-stratification survey weights. Error bars show 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) bootstrap confidence intervals. $n = 1,996$ (model-eligible respondents from the raked sample of 1,999).

The pooled estimate, however, masks a striking ideological pattern. Figure 4 disaggregates by self-placed ideology (1-10 scale, collapsed to Progressive, Centrist, and Conservative). The growth cue produces opposite-direction movement across the spectrum. Centrists consolidate Maintain by 11.0 points, from 46.0% in the control arm to 57.0% under the growth cue, with Increase falling 8.4 points. Conservatives consolidate Maintain by 11.9 points (40.2% to 52.1%), with Decrease falling 6.4 points. Progressives, however, move in the opposite direction. Their Maintain share falls 15.7 points (50.6% to 34.9%), and the share selecting Decrease more than doubles, from 9.8% to 22.3%, an absolute shift of 12.5 percentage points among the ideological group that should have been the easiest target for pro-immigration persuasion.

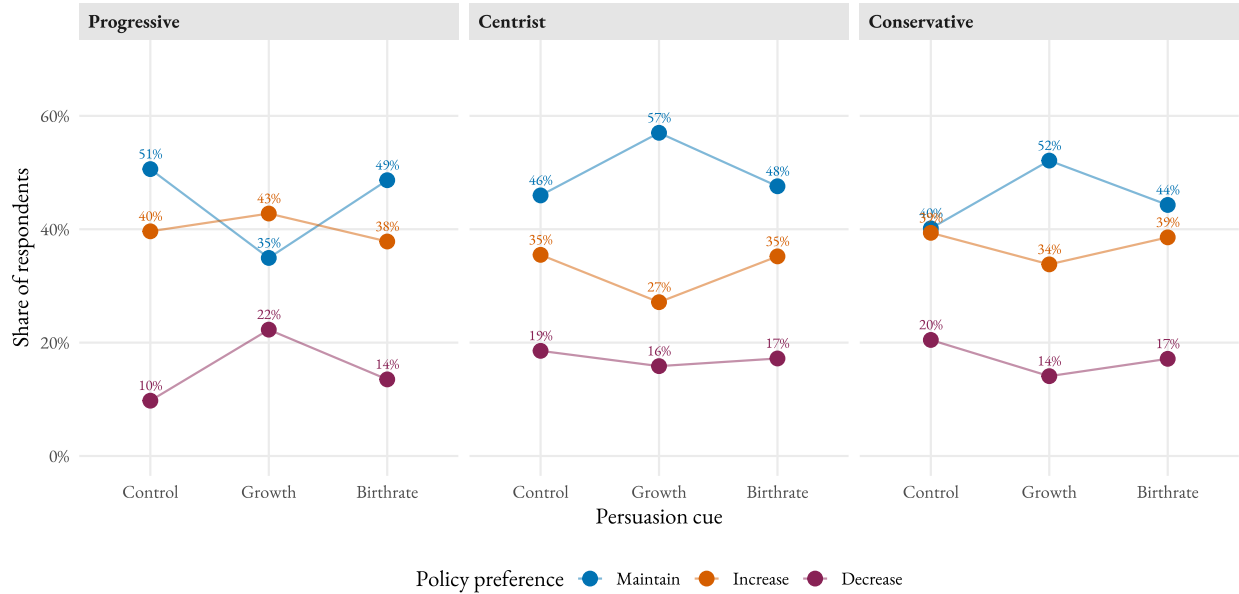


Figure 4: Predicted policy preferences by persuasion cue, disaggregated by ideology.

Note: Cell shares within ideology $\times$ frame. Ideology measured pre-treatment on a 1-10 self-placement and collapsed to three groups: Progressive (1-4), Centrist (5-6), Conservative (7-10). Within-cell n ranges from 127 to 372.

The growth $\times$ ideology interactions are highly significant: in a linear-probability model with respondent-clustered standard errors and demographic controls, Growth $\times$ Centrist on Maintain is +20.6 percentage points ($p=.002$), and Growth $\times$ Conservative on Maintain is +26.2 percentage points ($p<.001$). Decrease shows the mirror pattern: Growth $\times$ Centrist on Decrease is -13.0 pp ($p=.010$), Growth $\times$ Conservative is -15.2 pp ($p=.011$). The fertility cue produces no comparable ideological polarization.

This pattern is inconsistent with all three of the families of expectations we framed in Section 2.1 as uniform-population predictions. Druckman-style persuasion (Expectation 1) predicts liberalization in the cue's argued direction; we observe restrictionism among the ideologically nearest group. Coppock-Wood parallel updating predicts that all groups move in the same direction; we observe opposite-sign movement. Status-quo activation as conceived by Arceneaux and Nicholson (2023) (Expectation 3) predicts uniform consolidation toward the salient anchor; the Korean progressive moves *away* from the anchor. The pattern is consistent instead with a fourth expectation we did not formally enumerate: a *source-cue* or *elite-consensus rejection* effect of the kind documented by Nicholson (2012) and Berinsky (2009), in which

an executive-branded message is rejected by partisans of the out-party even when its content matches their priors. The cue’s pro-immigration content is consistent with progressive priors, but the cue is also unmistakably the South Korean executive’s framing, which Yoon (2022-2025) and Lee (2025-) have both invoked. Progressives reading the cue as a Yoon/Lee-aligned message reject the policy posture rather than the content.

Equivalence tests at a five-percentage-point SESOI confirm that the polarization pattern is not a noise artifact. The growth cue’s 20.6pp Centrist-vs-Progressive Maintain interaction sits well outside the SESOI band, and the 12.5pp progressive Decrease shift falls just outside it. The pooled fertility-cue effects on Increase, by contrast, are underpowered nulls: the data are consistent with anything from a small liberalizing effect to a small consolidation effect but rule out a large effect in either direction. The asymmetry between the polarizing growth cue and the modest fertility cue at the policy-preference level sets up the second result, where the fertility cue does considerable cognitive work but at the conjoint margin rather than on aggregate preference.

For completeness, we also report results by sociotropic baseline orientation (Appendix C, Figure C.1). Among optimists (top quartile of the sociotropic composite), the control-arm distribution is 31% Maintain, 63% Increase, 5% Decrease; the growth cue lifts Maintain 13 points and reduces Increase 16 points. Among skeptics, the cue lifts Maintain 11 points. The pattern qualitatively matches the ideology pattern: the cue consolidates Maintain among groups whose priors are not far from the cue’s content. Subgroup interactions with treatment in the multinomial logit are not statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels, likely reflecting limited statistical power at subgroup sample sizes (each at $n \approx 200$ within arm).

4.2 Pooled Conjoint Admission Preferences

Before stratifying by framing arm, we summarize the average admission-preference structure that the conjoint produces across all respondents and all framing arms. The full attribute hierarchy of marginal means is reported in the Supplementary Information (Appendix C, Figure C.2); here we report the largest patterns and use them as the baseline against which the framing-stratified analyses in Sections 4.3 and 4.4

are read.

Three attributes carry the largest variation in selection probability: Korean-language fluency (a 21.7-percentage-point range from *No Korean* at 36.8% to *Fluent* at 58.5%); religion (a 14.8-point range, with the *Muslim* level at 39.1% well below the *Non-religious* baseline at 53.9%); and country of origin (an 11.8-point range, with China at 42.9% and the United States at 54.7%). The next four attributes carry smaller but non-trivial ranges: occupation (10.5pp, with Computer Programmer at 55.1% above Unemployed at 44.6%), employment history (7.9pp, with prior work in Korea above no work history), ethnicity (a 7.5pp Korean-vs-non-Korean gap), and profile age (6.9pp, with younger profiles preferred). Marital status, Korea visit history, years in Korea, and profile sex carry the smallest ranges (under 6pp each). Korean fluency on its own is large enough to override origin: a Fluent Chinese profile is selected at 50.8%, beating a No-Korean American profile at 41.3%.

Two substantive points follow before we stratify by frame. The dominant attribute pattern is integrationist rather than ascriptive. Acquired civic markers (language, work history, time in Korea) carry as much or more weight than the unalterable ones (origin, ethnicity). And the largest individual penalties in the design are religion-based (Muslim) and origin-based (China), not the ethnic-Korean / non-ethnic-Korean penalty that the prior literature on hierarchical nationhood would predict to dominate at the public-attitude level (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Denney and Green, 2021). Both patterns matter for interpreting the framing manipulation. Origin and religion penalties of 10 to 14 percentage points are an order of magnitude larger than the framing-experiment shifts on policy preference, which means a 5pp framing effect on a non-trivial subset of cells is substantively interpretable but does not displace the underlying hierarchy.

4.3 Origin and Religion Penalties Are Stable Across Frames

Against the polarization and ethnic-restoration findings, the conjoint also exhibits considerable stability where the rejected version of this paper foregrounded it. Figure 5 reports AMCEs and marginal means for origin and ethnicity by framing arm. In the control arm, profiles from China are 10.4 percentage points less likely to be selected than profiles from the United States; profiles from Indonesia are 6.2 points less

preferred; profiles from Brazil are 4.1 points less preferred. Non-ethnic Korean profiles face a 7.4-point penalty relative to ethnic Korean profiles. These effects are larger than the framing-experiment shifts on policy preference and are essentially independent of treatment arm. The absolute AMCEs change by no more than 2.5 points across the three arms, and these treatment-by-origin AMCE differences are below the design’s MDE for interactions (about 4.9 percentage points; see Appendix D).

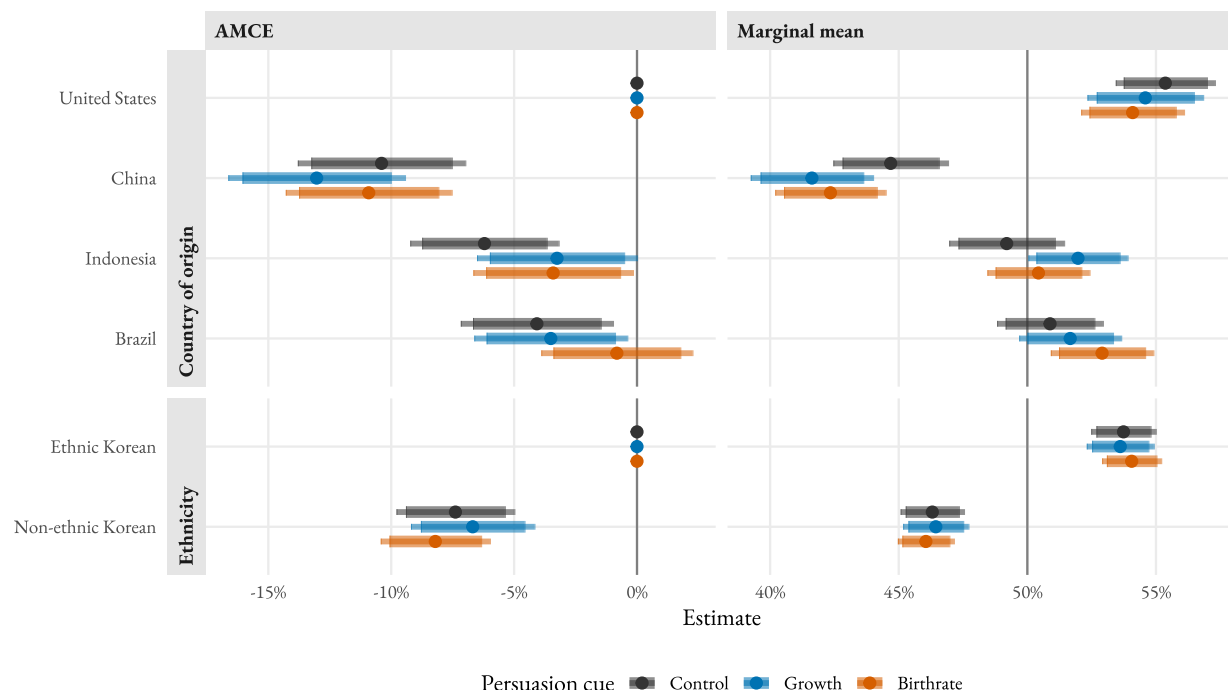


Figure 5: AMCEs and marginal means for origin and ethnicity, by persuasion cue.

Note: Average Marginal Component Effects (left) report deviation from the baseline category (United States for origin, Ethnic Korean for ethnicity); Marginal Means (right) report absolute selection probability. 0.5 = chance selection. Error bars are 95% confidence intervals from `clogg::cj()` with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights.

The Muslim penalty has the same property. Muslim profiles draw a marginal mean of 0.40 versus 0.54 for non-religious profiles, an effective gap of 14 percentage points that is essentially identical across all three framing arms. The penalty is not Indonesia-driven: Muslim profiles from Brazil draw a 15.0pp penalty, Muslim from China 13.4pp, Muslim from the United States 13.9pp, all relative to non-religious profiles of the same origin. Religious distance from the South Korean baseline operates as a generalized cue that travels independently of origin. This pattern parallels the comparative European (Bansak et al.,

2016; Helbling and Traunmüller, 2020) and Japanese (Fraser and Cheng, 2024) conjoint findings.

The skill premium operates roughly equally across origins. Computer Programmer profiles are selected at 55.1%, Office Worker at 51.1%, Agricultural Worker at 49.4%, and Unemployed at 44.6%, a pooled high-vs-low skill premium of about 6 percentage points. The China penalty is essentially unchanged across the four occupation levels, contradicting the high-skill by China interaction reported in earlier presentations of this work. The C₄ fielded instrument we analyze here gives a null origin by skill interaction ($F=0.23$, $p=.88$). Detailed numerical interaction estimates are in Appendix Tables C.3 and C.4.

The picture from the headline AMCEs is one of stability. The framing manipulation, even with its anti-discrimination "regardless of background" language and the post-task-4 reinforcement, does not displace the deepest origin and religion penalties. The next subsection turns to the one cue-by-cell pattern that does move: the fertility cue's selective rehabilitation of unemployed ethnic-Korean candidates.

4.4 The Fertility Cue Activates an Ethnic-Restoration Heuristic

The fertility cue's small average effect on policy preference does not mean the cue is inert in the conjoint. While the headline origin and religion penalties documented in Section 4.3 remain stable across frames, one specific cell-level pattern moves substantially under the fertility cue. Figure 6 reports marginal means for occupation by ethnicity, faceted by frame.

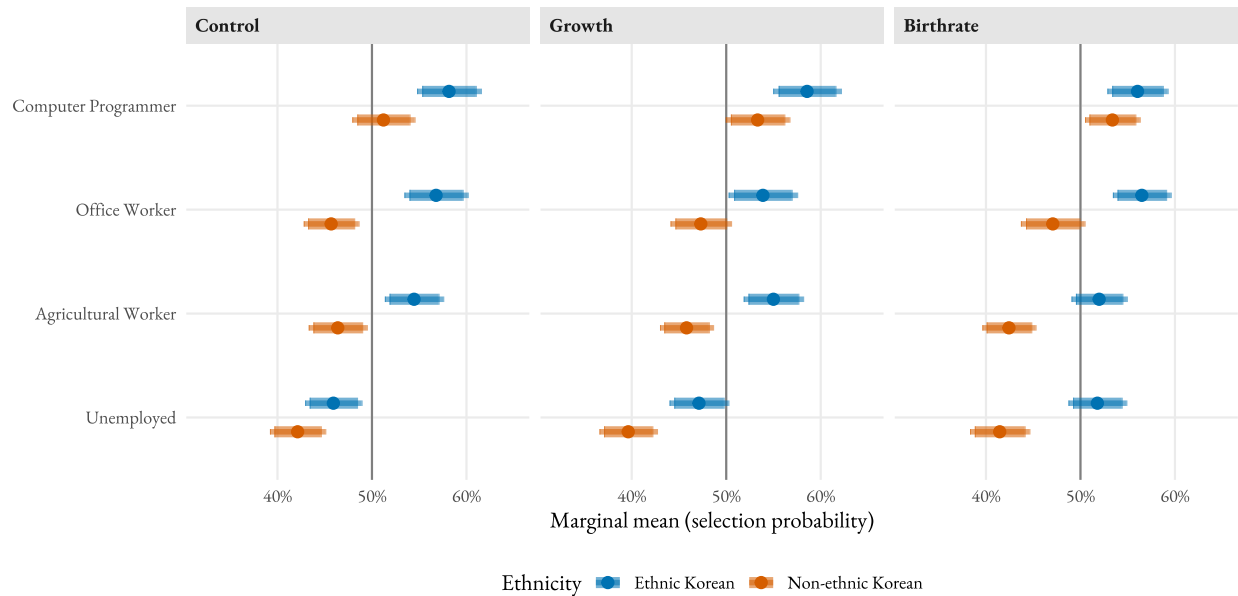


Figure 6: Occupation marginal means by ethnicity, by persuasion cue.

Note: Marginal means with 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) confidence intervals from `cregg::cj()` with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights. Sample $n = 1,999$.

Across all four occupation levels, only one cell moves substantially under the fertility cue: ethnic-Korean profiles coded as *Unemployed*. Their selection probability rises from 45.9% under control to 51.8% under birthrate, a 5.6-percentage-point linear-probability effect ($p < .001$) that is robust to controls for all other attributes. The unemployment penalty for ethnic Koreans, defined as Computer Programmer minus Unemployed, falls from 12.2 to 4.3 percentage points under the fertility cue. For non-ethnic Korean profiles, the equivalent unemployment penalty barely moves (Control 11.5pp, Birthrate 12.0pp). The growth cue produces no equivalent rehabilitation. If anything, it widens the unemployment penalty.

We interpret this pattern as a *demographic-urgency deservingness gate*. Reminded that South Korea needs more immigrants to address fertility decline, respondents drop the work-history filter for co-ethnic candidates only. The mechanism is not generic openness. It is a targeted rehabilitation of ethnically eligible candidates whose current labor-market status would otherwise disqualify them. The cue activates an ethnic-restoration logic that already operates in South Korean immigration policy through the Overseas Korean Act and F-4 visas, but extends it at the public-attitude level to candidates the formal regime would not have qualified.

A complementary pattern appears at the origin level. The fertility cue produces a 10.6-point Brazil-vs-China swap among low-skill profiles: Brazil rises from 46.4% to 51.7%, while China falls from 42.8% to 37.5%. Brazil is a partial co-ethnic case (it hosts approximately 50,000 Korean Brazilians, Korea's third-largest co-ethnic diaspora), and the swap is concentrated on ethnic-Korean Brazilian low-skill profiles. China remains the politically charged exception. Two further pieces of evidence triangulate the mechanistic claim. First, the Brazil-vs-China swap is concentrated in respondents aged 30-39, the cohort for whom childbearing is most cognitively accessible. Under birthrate framing, this cohort selects Brazilian profiles at 55.4% (vs. 49.8% Control) while their China selection rate is unchanged. Second, woman-coded Brazilian profiles benefit more from the fertility cue (50.6% Control to 52.9% Birthrate) than man-coded Brazilian profiles do, while woman-coded American profiles *lose* (57.4% to 54.4%). Both patterns are consistent with the cue activating a literal reproductive-contribution reading of "fertility crisis," not a generic positive-other-aiding response.

Taken together, the conjoint findings are stable on the headline penalties and selectively responsive on a co-ethnic-deservingness margin. Pro-immigration framing in this design does real cognitive work where the rejected version read it as flat, but the work is targeted rather than aggregate.

5 Conclusion

This study examined whether pro-immigration messages framed around economic growth and demographic decline could shift South Korean attitudes toward immigration policy and toward immigrant-admission criteria. The headline result of the rebuilt analysis is that such framing is neither uniformly persuasive nor uniformly null. It is selective. Each cue activates a particular cognitive heuristic, and the heuristics it activates are not the ones a generic "framing fails on immigration" reading would lead us to expect.

The growth cue produces a meaningful 6.6-point lift in support for maintaining current immigration levels at the population average, but the population average is misleading. Decomposed by ideology, the cue operates in opposite directions: centrists and conservatives consolidate Maintain by 11 to 12 percentage

points, while progressives more than double their share selecting *Decrease* (9.8% to 22.3%) and reduce their Maintain share by 16 points. The interactions are highly significant ($p=.002$ and $p<.001$ respectively). This is the cleanest piece of evidence in the data and it does not fit the parallel-updating consensus, the status-quo-activation account, or the Druckman competitive-frames model as uniform-population mechanisms. We read it as a source-cue effect: the executive-branded growth message is rejected by progressives on partisan source grounds even where its content matches their priors.

The fertility cue, despite producing only small average policy-preference effects, activates an ethnic-restoration heuristic in the conjoint. It rehabilitates unemployed ethnic-Korean profiles (the unemployment penalty for co-ethnics drops from 12 to 4 percentage points) and produces a 10.6-point Brazil-vs-China swap among low-skill profiles. The pattern is concentrated on ethnic-Korean Brazilian profiles, woman-coded profiles, and respondents in the 30-39 cohort whose biographic position makes the fertility frame most cognitively accessible. The mechanism is targeted rather than generic. The fertility cue reweights the work-history filter for co-ethnic candidates and redirects low-skill admission preferences toward the smaller, less politically charged co-ethnic-diaspora origin.

Origin- and religion-based penalties stay roughly fixed under both cues at magnitudes consistent with cross-national work. The China origin penalty (about 10 percentage points) operates regardless of skill, ethnicity, or framing arm. The Muslim penalty (about 14 percentage points) operates uniformly across origins. These stabilities are themselves substantive findings, replicating the rejected paper's headline at higher precision while showing that the framing manipulation is conservative against, rather than supportive of, the discrimination patterns.

Two implications for policy and political communication follow. In elite-consensus contexts where pro-immigration framing is already the official line, generic sociotropic messaging can polarize rather than mobilize. The growth cue's progressive backlash is a cautionary case for governments considering a national pro-immigration campaign. Specific arguments tied to identifiable beneficiaries and source-diverse delivery appear in the comparative literature to be more effective (Kustov, 2024; Hopkins et al., 2026; Nicholson, 2012). The demographic-urgency deservingness gate identified by the fertility cue suggests that policy framing keyed to specific benefits (co-ethnic restoration, fertility, regional labor shortages) produces more

targeted attitudinal change than generic openness messaging. The cue does not change minds about China or Islam, but it does change them about co-ethnic Korean Brazilians who would otherwise be filtered out on work-history grounds.

Theoretically, the findings contribute to ongoing debates in two ways. They identify a boundary condition on the parallel-updating consensus: pro-immigration framing in elite-consensus contexts produces source-cue rather than informational effects, and the source-cue effects can run in opposite directions across the ideological spectrum. They also specify a mechanism (the demographic-urgency deservingness gate) by which fertility framing produces selective attitudinal change without producing aggregate movement, complicating both Kustov's salience-not-direction account (Kustov, 2024) and the standard "no effect" reading of immigration framing nulls.

As to limitations, our framing manipulation is a single-paragraph cue rather than a full media-environment manipulation, so effect sizes are bounded above by the strength of the cue. The polarization and ethnic-restoration findings, however, are robust to this scaling. They emerge inside a single-paragraph cue, and the comparative literature suggests that real-world media-environment manipulation should amplify rather than dampen them. An additional avenue for future research concerns the intersection of demographic decline, national security, and immigration. In South Korea, population aging and low fertility are also security concerns in a state that maintains compulsory military service under persistent threat from North Korea. Whether security-oriented cues, linking immigration to sustaining national defense capacity, affect public opinion in similarly polarizing ways is an important extension that our design does not address (Bigo, 2002).

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Supplementary Information for “Persuasion and Prejudice:
Are South Korean Attitudes Toward Immigration Open to
Change?”

Appendix A Additional Survey Information

The survey was fielded through Qualtrics’ online panel in January 2024, recording responses from 2,004 native-born South Koreans (1,999 after excluding respondents missing on raking dimensions). To ensure semi-representativeness, quotas were established in alignment with the most up-to-date demographic parameters from Statistics Korea (KOSIS, January 2024). Multiple quality-assurance steps were included: Qualtrics’ inbuilt quality controls, a manual attention check (*Q7_28*: “Please select strongly disagree”), and a Korean-citizen screen. Responses that failed quality criteria were replaced following review and consultation with the Qualtrics project manager. The final dataset comprises legitimate and valid survey responses. To correct for over- and under-sampling, especially for education, we added post-stratification weights using the raking method (survey package in R) on age group, sex, education, and a five-category region (collapsing the seventeen administrative districts to capital, capital region, southeast, southwest, and other). Table A.1 reports unweighted sample counts and weighted proportions.

Variable	Count	Proportion	Weighted Prop.
Age			
18-29	357	17.9%	17.5%
30-39	348	17.4%	15.7%
40-49	397	19.9%	16.6%
50-59	529	26.5%	21.5%
60+	369	18.4%	28.6%
Sex			
Man	1,015	50.7%	50.0%
Woman	989	49.3%	50.0%
Education			
No University	388	19.4%	45.5%
University	1,616	80.6%	54.5%
Region (collapsed)			
Capital (Seoul)	873	43.7%	29.5%
Capital region (Gyeonggi, Incheon)	555	27.8%	20.9%
Southeast (Gyeongsang, Busan, Daegu, Ulsan)	264	13.2%	23.1%
Southwest (Jeolla, Gwangju)	103	5.2%	11.7%
Other (Chungcheong, Gangwon, Daejeon, Sejong, Jeju)	208	10.4%	14.8%

Table A.1: Summary counts, proportions, and weighted proportions: South Korea (n = 1,999)

Appendix B Survey Questions

This section provides the text used for the background questions, the policy-preference dependent variable, the sociotropic battery, and the framing-cue messages.

Background questions:

- Q₂ (sex at birth): Male / Female
- Q₃ (current residence): 17 administrative regions
- Q₄ (age): validated numeric input
- Q₅ (highest education): No formal / Elementary or below / Middle school / High school / Some college / University / Graduate / Other
- Q_{12_1} (ideology): 1-10 sliding scale (1 = very progressive, 10 = very conservative)
- Q₁₄ (party preference, hypothetical national election tomorrow): People Power Party / Minjoo Party / Green-Justice Party / Other Party / Don't know

Sociotropic-attitude battery (Q_{27_1} through Q_{27_6}): “Please rate how much you agree with the following items: (1 = strongly agree, 4 = neutral, 7 = strongly disagree).”

- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of the domestic agricultural industry.
- The influx of foreign workers financially secures pensions, stabilizes the population, and increases birth rates.
- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of the domestic financial sector.
- The influx of foreign workers is beneficial to Korea.
- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of domestic manufacturing.
- The influx of foreign workers is essential to domestic economic growth.

We reverse-code the items so that higher composite scores indicate more pro-immigration sentiment. Sociotropic optimists are coded as the top quartile of the composite (75th percentile cut, $n = 358$); the rest are skeptics ($n = 1,022$).

Framing cue messages (verbatim from instrument):

- *Control*: “Next, you will be asked your opinion about immigration. You will rate the immigrant profile as if you were an immigration officer.”
- *Economic Growth Cue*: “The government believes that the only way to maintain economic competitiveness and a high standard of living is to accept more immigrants, regardless of their background. Next, you'll be asked for your opinion on immigration. You will rate immigrant profiles as if you were an immigration officer.”

- *Fertility Crisis Cue*: “South Korea has one of the lowest fertility rates among advanced industrialized countries. The government believes that the only way to solve the economic and social problems caused by the low birth rate is to accept more immigrants, regardless of their background. Next, you will be asked for your opinion on immigration. You will rate immigrant profiles as if you were an immigration officer.”

The cue is reinforced after the fourth conjoint task with a shortened “Remember, the government believes ...” restatement.

Policy-preference DV (Q4_120): “In your view, should immigration levels be maintained at current levels, increased, or decreased?” (single-choice).

Conjoint task instructions (verbatim English translation): “To pilot a new policy, the immigration office is reviewing applications from legal residents. You have been assigned to review applications under this pilot. You will see profiles of two immigrants who came to Korea. Of these two, please select the one you think is more suitable to be admitted.”

Appendix C Additional Figures and Tables

This section presents supplementary figures and tables. The numerical estimates underlying the headline polarization, ethnic-restoration, and language-dominance findings reported in the main text (Sections 4.1-4.3) are produced by the analysis pipeline at `code/09_novel_findings.R`; the consolidated outputs are saved to `data/processed/polarization.rds`, `ethnic_restoration.rds`, and `attribute_hierarchy`.

Figure C.1 reports subgroup results by sociotropic baseline orientation (optimists vs. skeptics). The growth cue produces a large consolidation effect in both groups; the fertility cue produces small shifts.

Figure C.2 presents marginal means for all conjoint attributes, including those not foregrounded in the main text (occupation, language, religion, marital status, age, years in Korea, employment history, Korea visit history, sex). The figure provides a complete picture of which attributes structure immigrant-admission preferences.

Tables C.1, C.2, and C.3 report regression-based estimates underlying the framing-experiment and origin-by-frame analyses in the main text.

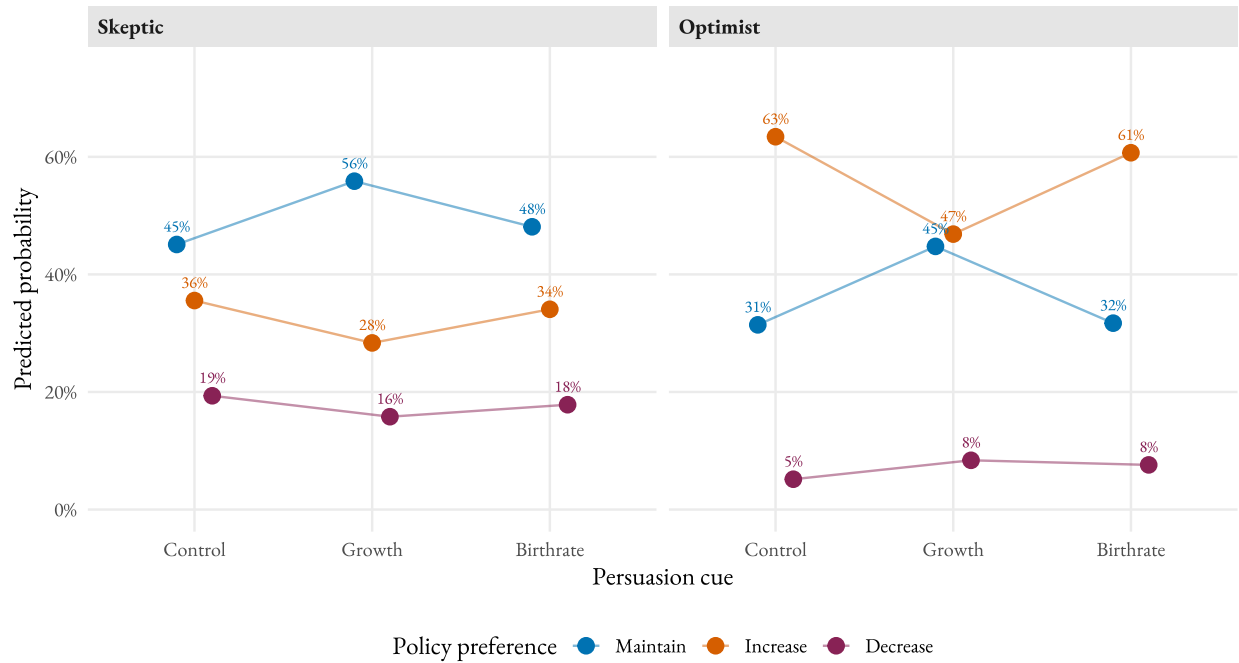


Figure C.1: Persuasion cues and immigration policy preferences, by sociotropic baseline orientation.

Note: Predicted probabilities from multinomial logistic regression with controls and survey weights. Optimists are the top quartile of the pre-treatment sociotropic composite (75th percentile cut); skeptics are the rest. Within-arm n: optimists $\approx$ 110-130; skeptics $\approx$ 230-260.

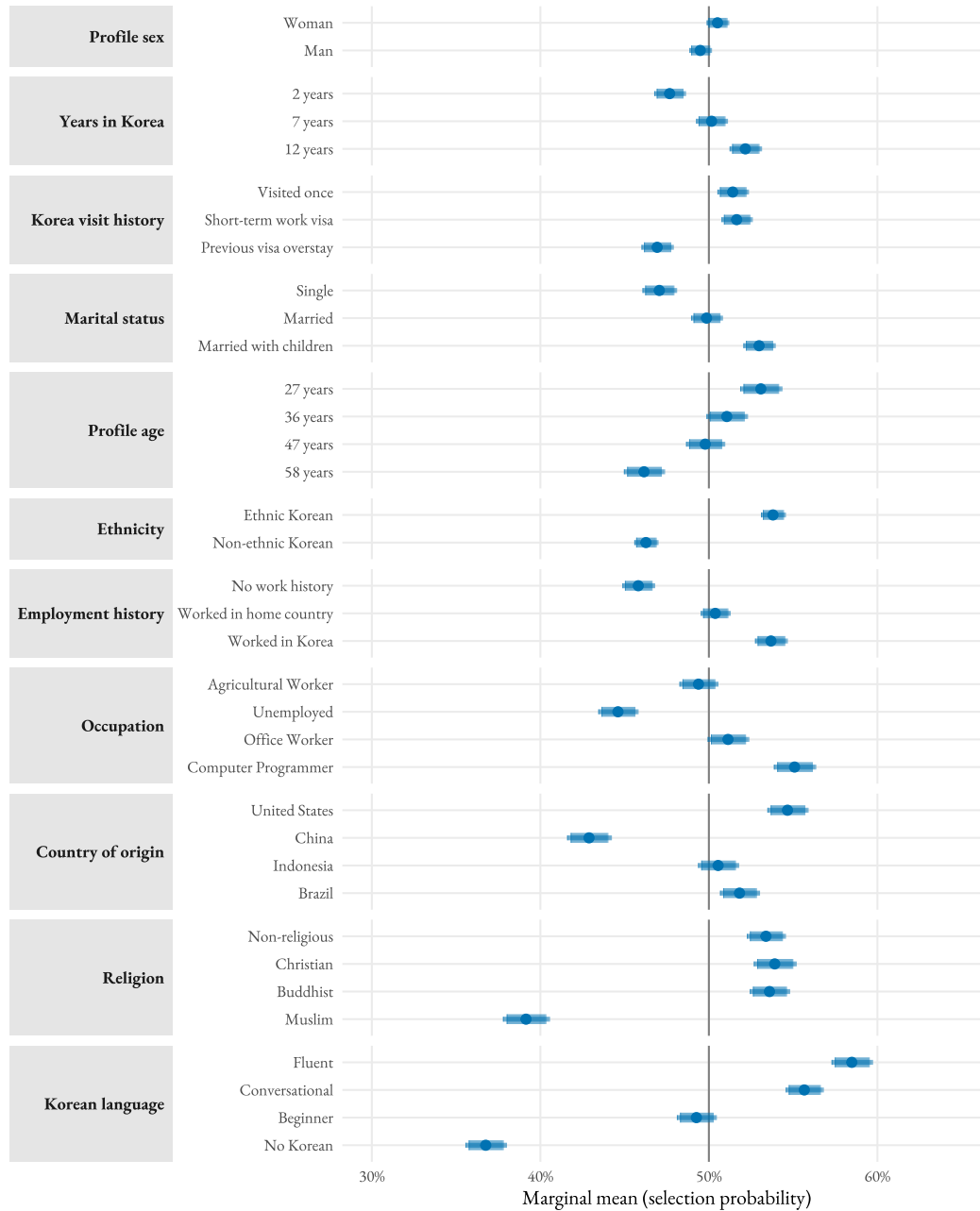


Figure C.2: Marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels, pooled across framing arms.

Note: 0.5 marks chance selection. Error bars show 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) confidence intervals from `clogg::cj()` with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights.

Outcome	Term	Estimate	SE	z	p
Decrease	frameBirthrate	0.0365	0.1553	0.235	0.8142
Decrease	frameGrowth	-0.1952	0.1590	-1.228	0.2196
Increase	frameBirthrate	-0.1216	0.1265	-0.961	0.3367
Increase	frameGrowth	-0.3131	0.1282	-2.442	0.0146

Table C.1: Multinomial logit treatment coefficients (relative to Maintain baseline). Controls: sex, age group, education, region, ideology, partisanship. Survey weights applied; cluster-robust SEs.

Variable	Estimate	SE	z-statistic	p-value
Support Increase				
Birthrate Prime	-0.0569	0.1484	-0.383	0.7015
Growth Prime	-0.1413	0.1533	-0.922	0.3566
Sociotropic Optimists	1.2567	0.1845	6.811	< 0.0001
Growth Prime $\times$ Optimists	-0.1769	0.2612	-0.677	0.4983
Birthrate Prime $\times$ Optimists	0.0972	0.2651	0.367	0.7139
Support Decrease				
Birthrate Prime	0.0615	0.1542	0.399	0.6900
Growth Prime	-0.1285	0.1610	-0.798	0.4248
Sociotropic Optimists	-1.4836	0.3140	-4.726	< 0.0001
Growth Prime $\times$ Optimists	-0.1637	0.4810	-0.340	0.7337
Birthrate Prime $\times$ Optimists	-0.8832	0.5782	-1.528	0.1265
Support Maintain				
Birthrate Prime	0.0017	0.1300	0.013	0.9896
Growth Prime	0.1936	0.1332	1.453	0.1463
Sociotropic Optimists	-0.5354	0.1804	-2.967	0.0030
Growth Prime $\times$ Optimists	0.2004	0.2519	0.796	0.4262
Birthrate Prime $\times$ Optimists	0.0760	0.2581	0.294	0.7686

Table C.2: Multinomial logit treatment effects by sociotropic orientation

Note: Reference categories: Control treatment, Sociotropic Skeptics. Survey weights applied; cluster-robust SEs.

Treatment Contrast	Origin Contrast	Estimate	SE	t-statistic	p-value
Growth – Control					
Growth – Control	China – USA	-0.026	0.025	-1.04	0.298
Growth – Control	Indonesia – USA	0.030	0.023	1.30	0.193
Growth – Control	Brazil – USA	0.006	0.022	0.27	0.787
Birthrate – Control					
Birthrate – Control	China – USA	-0.005	0.024	-0.21	0.834
Birthrate – Control	Indonesia – USA	0.028	0.023	1.22	0.224
Birthrate – Control	Brazil – USA	0.033	0.022	1.50	0.134

Table C.3: Treatment $\times$ Origin AMCE differences (Prime – Control), pooled.

Note: AMCE differences for each origin relative to USA, computed as (Prime - Control). Weighted OLS with respondent-clustered SEs.

Appendix D Power, Minimum Detectable Effect, and Equivalence Tests

The achieved sample is $n = 1,999$ native-born South Korean respondents recruited through Qualtrics in January 2024, with random assignment to one of three framing arms (control, growth, fertility) producing arm sizes of approximately 660 to 700 respondents. The conjoint module presented ten paired-profile tasks per respondent, yielding approximately 39,980 profile-level observations clustered within 1,999 respondents (about 13,300 per arm). We treat the respondent as the unit of clustering and compute robust standard errors accordingly (Esarey and Menger, 2019).

To benchmark the precision of our estimates, we compute minimum detectable effects (MDEs) on the percentage-point scale for two-sided tests at $\alpha = 0.05$ and 80% power, using the closed-form expressions in Schuessler and Freitag (2020). The within-respondent intraclass correlation in the conjoint outcome (forced choice) is approximately zero by design (each respondent has exactly five chosen and five unchosen profiles), so the design effect is approximately 1. Table D.1 reports MDEs for the principal estimand classes.

Estimand class	Profiles per cell	MDE (pp)
Pooled main-effect AMCE (e.g., Ethnicity)	19,990	1.40
Within-arm pooled AMCE	3,332	3.43
Treatment x origin AMCE difference	3,332	4.85
Treatment x origin x ethnicity (3-way) AMCE difference	1,666	6.86
Treatment x origin x skill (3-way)	1,666	6.86

Table D.1: Minimum detectable effect (MDE) by estimand class.

Note: Two-sided $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.8. MDEs use the achieved sample, the within-respondent intraclass correlation estimated from the data ($\rho \approx 0$), and the implied design effect ($DEFF \approx 1$). The within-arm and three-way MDEs are the pooled MDE inflated by $\sqrt{2}$ for the relevant contrast.

Several of the directional effects highlighted in the manuscript fall below these MDEs. The fertility-cue modifications of the low-skill origin penalty (Indonesia +2.3, Brazil +5.3, China −5.3 percentage points) are substantively interesting but lie around or beneath the 4.85-point MDE for treatment-by-

origin interactions. Reporting them as null effects under conventional NHST is therefore misleading: the design lacks the precision to distinguish these from a true effect in the 1.5- to 5-point range. Equivalence testing with a justified SESOI clarifies what the evidence supports: the absence of *large* effects, not the absence of effects (Lakens, 2017; Rainey, 2014).

We adopt a SESOI of five percentage points for treatment-by-origin interactions and policy-preference shifts. Five points represents one-third of the largest origin penalty observed in the experiment (the China-versus-U.S. AMCE of approximately 10 points) and approximates the smallest shift that would alter South Korea’s stratified visa hierarchy in observable terms. An EPS quota adjustment of comparable magnitude affects roughly twenty thousand workers per year. Following Lakens et al. (2018), we use the two one-sided tests procedure: each effect estimate is tested against -0.05 and $+0.05$, and equivalence to zero (within the SESOI band) is concluded only when both one-sided tests reject. We report the upper bound of the 90% confidence interval for each effect as the effect-size ceiling, following Rainey (2014).

For the framing-experiment policy-preference effects, we report the following equivalence-test conclusions (full numerical output is generated by the analysis pipeline):

- **Growth - Control on Maintain (+6.5pp, 90% CI: 0.5 to 11.9):** *Not equivalent to zero.* The point estimate falls outside the SESOI band. Substantively meaningful consolidation effect.
- **Growth - Control on Increase (-5.8pp, 90% CI: -11.2 to 0):** Not equivalent to zero. Consolidation pulls primarily from the Increase category.
- **Growth - Control on Decrease (-0.8pp, 90% CI: -5.2 to 3.3):** *Equivalent to zero within the SESOI band.*
- **Birthrate - Control on Maintain (+1.9pp, 90% CI: -3.6 to 7.9):** Not equivalent to zero. Underpowered null.
- **Birthrate - Control on Increase (-3.0pp, 90% CI: -8.8 to 2.2):** Not equivalent to zero. Underpowered null.

- **Birthrate - Control on Decrease (+1.1pp, 90% CI: -3.2 to 5.7):** Not equivalent to zero. Underpowered null.

The conclusion is that we have substantive evidence of consolidation under the growth cue, while the fertility-cue effects on direction are too imprecise to characterize as substantively zero. The data are consistent with anything from a small liberalizing fertility-cue effect to a small consolidation effect, but rule out a large effect in either direction. For the conjoint, treatment-by-origin AMCE differences for the China contrast are similarly underpowered: the upper bound of the 90% CI on the Growth-Control China-USA contrast is +0.015 (1.5 percentage points), well within the SESOI; the upper bound for the Birthrate-Control China-USA contrast is +0.029 (2.9 percentage points). Larger origin penalties (the 10-point China main effect, the 7-point ethnicity effect, the 14-point Muslim penalty) are all detected with high power, well above the MDEs in Table D.1.

Appendix E Sociotropic Hierarchies and the Limits of Persuasion in Ethnonationalist Contexts

The body text develops the source-cue, status-quo-activation, and ethnic-restoration mechanisms. This appendix supplies the broader sociotropic-hierarchies framework that motivates why pro-immigration framing in South Korea operates against a particularly cohesive prior structure.

A large body of cross-national research shows that immigration attitudes track collective rather than personal welfare. Hainmueller and Hopkins (2014) and Valentino et al. (2019) document a sociotropic consensus: respondents asked to evaluate immigrants weight the projected effect on the national economy and national culture far more heavily than the projected effect on their own labour-market prospects. Sides and Citrin (2007) report a similar pattern in twenty European cases, where symbolic predispositions about cultural unity outperform indicators of personal economic dissatisfaction. The implication for policy framing is at first glance optimistic: if citizens reason about immigration in terms of national rather than private interest, then frames that link admission to national objectives, including economic competitiveness and demographic stability, should plausibly move opinion.

The implication holds only if the content of the relevant “national interest” is itself open to reframing. Recent work questions that premise. Bonikowski (2016) argues that nationalism in settled times functions as an everyday cognitive repertoire rather than an episodic ideology, with stable identity-based templates that organise how new political information is interpreted. Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) show that even within a single country, public nationalism partitions into distinct latent classes whose evaluations of immigrants differ sharply, and that the classes do not collapse onto the conventional civic-versus-ethnic axis. Reeskens and Hooghe (2010) report comparable variation across thirty-three countries: ethnic and civic citizenship criteria coexist in most populations, with the ethnic criterion typically operating as a necessary condition that civic criteria cannot override. Together this work indicates that sociotropic reasoning is filtered through prior commitments about who counts as part of the relevant collective, and that those commitments are not easily dislodged by short-term informational interventions.

This filtering matters for South Korea because the prior commitments are particularly cohesive. Shin (2006) traces the institutional reproduction of *minjok*-based ethnic nationalism across the colonial, developmental, and democratic periods, and Ha et al. (2016) document its endurance through the joint salience of shared ancestry and shared language. Campbell (2015) argues that ethnic nationalism is being reworked rather than replaced among younger cohorts, who increasingly add status-class criteria on top of ethnic ones rather than substituting them. The institutional record reinforces this layered pattern: the OKA and the F-4 visa privilege ethnic Koreans from advanced economies while excluding many Joseonjok and Goryeoins on perceived economic and assimilation grounds (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Chung, 2020; Song, 2023). Kim and Lee (2024) provide the most direct recent test of the resulting structure: in their conjoint and survey evidence, even co-ethnic North Korean refugees face significant prejudice once their identity content is read as contested, demonstrating that co-ethnicity is a necessary but not sufficient basis for inclusion. The emergent system is best read as a dual hierarchy in which ethnicity sets the outer boundary and class sets internal stratification, rather than as a single-dimensional nativism that economic frames could displace.

Theories of status threat help specify why pro-immigration economic framing in such a system can consolidate rather than liberalise attitudes. Mutz (2018) shows that perceived threat to dominant-group

status, rather than personal economic loss, predicts the most consequential recent shifts in American immigration politics. Outten et al. (2012) provide the experimental complement: even modest cues about anticipated demographic change activate defensive reactions among majority-group respondents, including increased prejudice and reduced support for diversity. Norris and Inglehart (2019) place the same dynamic in a comparative authoritarian-populist frame. The mechanism is interpretive rather than informational. When a state announces that immigration is necessary to maintain economic competitiveness, the announcement does not only convey a labour-market projection. It concedes that national prosperity is contingent on outsiders. For respondents whose sociotropic mental model anchors prosperity in ethnic continuity, that concession can read as a loss of collective control rather than as a solution to it.

The same logic accounts for the persistent origins penalty in the conjoint results. Ford (2011) shows the British public reproduces a stable ranking of admissibility with substantial penalties for the most culturally distant origins, and Bansak et al. (2016) document a parallel hierarchy for asylum seekers across fifteen European countries, including a strong anti-Muslim premium that is largely independent of voter characteristics. Fraser and Cheng (2024) extend the pattern to East Asia using a Japanese conjoint design closely comparable to ours, finding a clear native preference for white over non-white immigrants that persists across skill levels. Adida et al. (2010) formalise a related point at the receiving-society side: when ethnonational and religious priors are strong, the equilibrium between majority and minority groups is sustained by mutual expectation rather than by individual information, so that frames addressed to the majority cannot move the equilibrium without symmetric movement on the minority side. Solodoch (2021) reaches a complementary conclusion using a Dutch conjoint experiment that separates sociotropic-civic from ethnocentric components of opposition: even where civic sociotropic concerns dominate the average effect, ethnocentric sorting structures the residual variation in ways that informational appeals cannot reach. In contexts where the ethnonational prior is dominant rather than residual, the room for informational frames is correspondingly smaller.

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